

Cat & Company

Issue 5

24 pp

A Mission To Carcosa

David White

Page 1

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Black Sabbath** on landing approach over Main St in Phoenecia, NY. The area is not heavily populated, but the center of town has a number of small markets and bar and grills.

Camillo Skragg (*from inside crew hull*)

All right, just a bit further out of the middle of town.

There's a spot *behind* the house, see if you can *set down there*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Black Sabbath** has landed in the backyard of **Camillo Skragg's** house. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** lead **Jinx Bubastis** and **Peter Cat** to the back door of the house.

Penny Skragg

It looks like there wasn't very much damage from when the troops pulled out.

Peter Cat

That's good.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The kitchen and pantry of **Camillo Skragg's** house. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** look around with some curiosity. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** follow close behind.

Camillo Skragg

On the *top floor* we have some *attic space*.

I was thinking you guys could set up there.

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

As would be expected from attic space, there is a staircase and railing leading down roughly in the middle of the room. One eave has turned into a small but useful bathroom; otherwise, the space has been left open. Several round windows let in light from the other eaves. A double bed was moved up here into another eave a while ago – neither Camillo nor Penny needed it – and there are a handful of surplus wardrobes and dressers. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** look around.

Peter Cat

Looks nice.

Jinx Bubastis

Yeah.

Page 2

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view very much like Page 1, Panel 1; **Peter Cat**, **Camillo Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Penny Skragg** walk in to “downtown” Phoenecia, NY.

Box (upper left, narration)

Phoenecia is not a large town.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis walks out of a clothing store, followed by **Peter Cat**, who is carrying a large stack of bags filled with clothing and towels for them both.

Box (lower left, narration)

Still, Peter and Jinx need *everything*.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg introduces **Peter Cat** to a shopkeeper.

Box (upper right, narration)

Introductions need to be made...

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis leaves a bookstore with a pile of basic reference material – things like atlases, almanacs, and the like – followed closely by **Camillo Skragg**.

Box (lower right, narration)

...and basic *information* gathered.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The exterior of the Steakhouse.

Peter Cat (from interior)

On the one hand, I’m grateful that we aren’t getting a ton of attention.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The interior of the Steakhouse. **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** sit at a long table. They have just finished a large meal, and are talking to the **Waitress**.

Peter Cat

On the other hand, it bothers me that *everything we’ve done* has been broken up into *three unrelated stories* that don’t make any sense.

Waitress

I don’t know, that’s kinda why I don’t bother trying to follow the news.
So *Tulsa* and *L.A.* were the *same guys*?

Camillo Skragg

Kind of.

Waitress

And that fight in *East L.A.* wasn’t a *deepfake*?

Penny Skragg

Hey! I was *there*.

Page 3

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A **young man** and a **young woman** seem to simply appear at one end of the table. **Peter Cat** and the others sit up and look at the strangers; the **Waitress** is frozen with surprise.

Young man

Salàm lacom! It is good we have found you.

Young woman

We bear an important message.

Peter Cat

We're *listening*.

Panel 2 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **young man** kneels before the **young woman**, who places a gauzy pale yellow hood or veil over his head.

Young woman (to the young man)

Are you ready?

Panel 3 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **young man** bows his head deeply, or droops. The shape of his skull seems to have changed; the forehead is large, round and protrudes outwards. The **Waitress** looks on in horror.

Waitress

Is that some kind of mask?

Panel 4 (*1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **young man** no longer looks like a young man – he has become **The King in Yellow**. As he lifts his head and gets to his feet, he has the hunched posture of an ancient old man. Along with his over-sized forehead is a large, straight nose. He grasps the edge of the table with an ancient, frail hand.

The King in Yellow

I wear no mask.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow stands next to the **young woman**, who appears to be in a trance. He stares down **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg**, while the **Waitress** stands there with a deer-in-the-headlights expression.

The King in Yellow

Fear not.

I bear an *invitation*.

You must *come to Carcosa*.

You will be my guests.

Page 4

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks at **The King in Yellow** evenly.

Peter Cat

Who *are* you?

The King in Yellow

I am called “The King in Yellow.”

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow pulls down one of his sleeves, revealing a tattoo of **the Yellow Sign**.

The King in Yellow

Some of my subjects *volunteer* to bear my mark...
...to let me speak through them.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A full view of the table. **The King in Yellow** points to **Jinx Bubastis**. **Peter Cat** observes **The King in Yellow** carefully. **Camillo Skragg** leans back in his chair and listens carefully. **Penny Skragg** leans on the table with her elbow.

Jinx Bubastis

What do you *need* from us?

The King in Yellow

For you, I have a *gift*.

Camillo Skragg

What about us?

The King in Yellow

There are *things* I can show you in *Carcosa*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow gestures towards the **young woman**.

The King in Yellow

She has a *sealed envelope* with all the details.
We will speak again.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **young man** snatches the veil from his head and gasps for breath. He seems to be unharmed by his transformation. The **young woman** fetches a large Manila envelope sealed with a wax impression of **the Yellow Sign**.

Page 5

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg checks on the **young man**.

Penny Skragg

Are you OK?

Young man

Yes!

It's disorienting, that's all.

Penny Skragg

Do you remember any of it?

Young man

Like a dream.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks at the papers from the envelope. He is quite puzzled. The **young woman** points to a spot on the sheet **Camillo Skragg** was holding.

Camillo Skragg

I... I don't understand.

There's no *text* on these pages.

Young woman

There's a QR code there.

Camillo Skragg

I see that, but why?

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up on the **young woman**.

Young woman

We have some *religious beliefs* about the *written word*.

Every village is built around a *library tower*, where we keep our writings *safe*.

Books, ledgers, personal journals...

...are *all* considered *sacred* and worthy of protection.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg flips through the documents on his smartphone.

Camillo Skragg

I see.

Airline tickets, hotel reservations, and...

...what is this? A *visa*?

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **young woman** and **young man** prepare to leave.

Young man

Yes, don't forget that.

Thank you for hearing us out.

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg smiles, and looks over to **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis**.

Camillo Skragg

No problem!

Camillo Skragg (to Peter Cat and Jinx Bubastis)

We're going to need to get you two *passports*.

Page 6

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat and **Jinx Bubastis** compare their passport photos as they stand in line with **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** at the check-in for **Air Hyades**, Carcosa's flag airline. The **Air Hyades** logo is 1 large black star, 3 smaller black stars at 10 o'clock, 1 o'clock, and 2 o'clock, and 1 final small black star at 11 o'clock. The stars are trimmed with yellow; the background is silver.

Peter Cat

I think *my* picture's worse.

Jinx Bubastis

At least you're *smiling*.

Penny Skragg

Hey, guys!

Looks like we're *boarding*.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The interior of the **Air Hyades** jet, a relatively small jetliner with a single aisle with a pair of seats on each side. **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** sit on one side of the aisle, and **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** sit on the other.

Penny Skragg

Huh, there's no *text* on the *safety card*.

It's just *pictograms*.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg talks to **Peter Cat** on the other side of the aisle.

Camillo Skragg

So, what do you think about *air travel*?

Peter Cat

It's OK. I was *curious*.

This might be *less cramped* than our ship.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis looks out the airplane window.

Jinx Bubastis

I think we'll be *landing* soon.

Panel 5 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Air Hyades** airliner approaches the city of **Hali**. While the center of town has a few tall skyscrapers, most of the rest of the town are low buildings made of marble. Towards the lake shore, there are broad thoroughfares and plazas. A few towers mark the skyline in these residential areas.

Announcement (Public Address system)

Visitors are reminded that the standard *tourist visa* does *not* permit leaving Hali city limits.

Cabin crew, prepare for landing.

Title

A Mission to Carcosa

Page 7

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat, Jinx Bubastis, Camillo Skragg, and Penny Skragg have picked up their bags at **Hali International Airport** and are waiting in front of the Immigration desk. The **Immigration officer** directs the foursome to a room off to the side.

Immigration officer

Ah! I see.
You have *unusual visas*...
...please enter the room to your *left*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Immigration officer** holds the door open as **Peter Cat, Jinx Bubastis, Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** sit at a table in front of a plain white backdrop. A **Witness** with a **Yellow Sign** tattoo on the back of his hand – much like the **young man** from the steakhouse in Phoenecia – prepares to give them a Significant Look.

Immigration officer

Please do not leave Hali on your own.
We will arrange transport to your final destination.

Camillo Skragg

Is it *dangerous*?

Witness

Not at all!
Please hold still.

Panel 3 (*1/4th page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks directly at the reader. He is calm but curious.

Witness (off-panel)

Look straight ahead and state your name.

Peter Cat

Peter Cat.

Panel 4 (*1/4th page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis looks directly at the reader. Her eyes are narrowed, and her face is tense – she is probing for threats.

Jinx Bubastis

Jinx Bubastis.

Panel 5 (*1/4th page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks directly at the reader. He looks tired.

Camillo Skragg

Camillo Skragg.

Panel 6 (*1/4th page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg looks directly at the reader. She is puzzled by this entire exercise.

Penny Skragg

Penelope Skragg.
Hey, is there a *camera* here somewhere?

Witness (off-panel)

Lèkad shahidu!
You have *been seen*.

Panel 7 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Viewed from above, **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** walk towards the reception of the hotel in Hali where they are staying. On the floor is a simplified map of the Hyades archipelago, with the names of the islands labeled. The layout is similar to the black stars in the **Air Hyades** logo. The large island in the middle with a prominent lake features a large black star. Next to that star is the name of the city, lake, and island – **Hali**. From west to east, the next three islands to the north are labeled “C. Oscura”, “C. Silente”, and “C. Perduta”. The northernmost island is labeled “Yhtill”.

Box (upper left)

After a brief taxi ride, they arrive at their hotel...

Jinx Bubastis

The city is *beautiful*.

Camillo Skragg

Reception's up ahead.

Let's *check in*, I'm *dead tired*.

Page 8

Panel 1 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg walks in to his hotel room.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg looks at the bed.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg lies down on the bed on top of the duvet, still wearing his clothes, and closes his eyes.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg dreams. He sits up from a flattened area in the middle of a field of tall red grass on the surface of the **archaeological site** from Issue 2.

Camillo Skragg (groggy)

What?

Here again?

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg is startled as a young, 8-year-old girl runs through the tall grass. Behind him, the huge red sun hangs in the sky.

Camillo Skragg

Hey!

Wait!

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg has followed the little girl towards another flattened area in the tall grass. **Jusef**, a young bearded man wearing a kufi and loose clothes, sits on a blanket, next to an open basket filled with food. The girl, his daughter **Surya**, keeps running through the grass.

Camillo Skragg

Hey!

What are *you* doing *here*?

Jusef

Salàm! I am *Jusef*.

We're having a *picnic*.

Panel 7 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Camillo Skragg sits down next to **Jusef** on the blanket.

Jusef

You've *been* here!

Recently!

I *envy* you.

Page 9

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg stretches out his hand to **Jusef**, who accepts the handshake.

Camillo Skragg

My name's *Camillo*.

Jusef

Pleased to meet you!

Camillo Skragg

Tell your daughter not to play near the ruins!

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jusef sits on the blanket and smiles.

Jusef

I have warned little Surya about the *hungry ghosts*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The gigantic red sun looms overhead above **Camillo Skragg** and **Jusef**.

Camillo Skragg

How did you *find* this place?

Jusef

People have visited it in *dreams* for a long, long time.

I'm *learning* how to read old *journals*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks up, seeming to notice something. **Jusef** smiles at him and turns away a little.

Camillo Skragg

Hey!

What's that?

Jusef

Is it *that time*?

We'll talk again soon!

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg sits up in bed, in a posture similar to his posture in Panel 4.

Camillo Skragg

Ahh!

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg has just walked out of the hotel; he is on the edge of a large plaza in the middle of Hali. Cafés and restaurants crowd around the edge of the plaza. He seems to be looking for something.

Box

Shortly, just outside the hotel...

Page 10

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg walks towards a chalkboard in front of a café. The phrase “You can talk about it here” is written in chalk on the chalkboard.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A **Waitress** points **Camillo Skragg** to the tables in the middle of the café. In the corner of the room is a small table with an odd-looking, straight-backed chair with no armrests made of dark-stained wood.

Waitress

You can sit *anywhere* but in the corner— that’s the *Stranger’s* place.

Camillo Skragg

Thanks!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg sees **Jusef** sitting at one of the tables, and reacts with mild surprise. **Jusef** looks up, smiles, and gestures to the other seat at his table.

Camillo Skragg

Jusef?

Jusef

Camillo! Please, have a seat!

Camillo Skragg

I feel like I *should* be surprised, but...

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jusef smiles broadly and pours a herbal liqueur into two small glasses.

Jusef

“Jilâl di achlêm l’rizhal tamtaddu en ashir.”

It’s an old saying.

“The shadows of men’s thoughts lengthen in the afternoon.”

Dreams are a kind of *public space* here.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg has taken a sip from his glass; **Jusef** is in the middle of taking his.

Camillo Skragg

And you learned about the colony from someone’s *journal*?

I don’t really understand the customs about *writing*.

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jusef gestures towards **Camillo Skragg** and talks with some animation.

Jusef

Ephemeral text – chalkboards, screens – these are *safe*.

Permanent text can anchor *thoughts* and *dreams* to the *real world*.

It invites *obsession* in a place where the boundaries are weak.

Page 11

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jusef continues talking, and **Camillo Skragg** listens attentively.

Jusef

A while ago I borrowed a *book* called “The Third Mind”.
Burroughs and *Gysin* fragmented and rearranged texts.
Our *wali* pointed us towards one passage in particular, the “Technical Deposition of the Virus Power.”
A moment where one of their “cut-ups” seemed to become *self-aware*
it “exhibited a capacity for life which is found elsewhere in the form of virus.”

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg looks a little puzzled. **Jusef** smiles and keeps talking.

Camillo Skragg

I’m not sure that I’m *following* you.

Jusef

Their *mechanical manipulations* of text seemed to show *glimpses* of a *mind* inside the written word.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg considers and speaks. Now **Jusef** listens.

Camillo Skragg

You know, they kind of do that with *large language models*.
Turn huge volumes of text into a *mathematical system* that predicts the next word given *what’s come before*.
It *feels* like you’re *talking to another person*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jusef cocks an eyebrow and asks **Camillo Skragg** a question.

Jusef

And do people *lose themselves* in *this illusion*?

Camillo Skragg

Yes. Yes, they do.

Jusef

Then I think you *understand* me.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg leans in through the open door to the café and calls to **Camillo Skragg**.

Penny Skragg

Hey, uncle!
Our *ride*’s waiting for us!

Camillo Skragg (to Penny Skragg)

Be right there...

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg stands up to leave. He shakes hands with **Jusef** as they part.

Jusef

It was a *pleasure*, Camillo!

Camillo Skragg

Thanks!

Take care.

Page 12

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A **white panel van** – like a Volkswagen Transporter – is parked in front of the hotel. The back doors are open; the back of the van is windowless. A **Yellow Sign**, in yellow, is on the rear of the side panels. A **Carcosan corporal** stands next to the open doors; he is in a recognizable uniform, but is only armed with a pistol in a holster hanging from his belt. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** are standing near the **Carcosan corporal**, waiting for **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** to catch up.

Carcosan corporal

Right this way...

Penny Skragg (*whispering, to Camillo Skragg*)

No windows?

Camillo Skragg (*whispering, to Penny Skragg*)

Nothing to see here...

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

While the interior of the back of the van has no windows, it is not unpleasant – six bucket seats with dark upholstery, which matches the fabric covering on the walls. **Jinx Bubastis** sits in the front left, wearing her seatbelt; the environment reminds her of a spacecraft. **Peter Cat** looks back over the left shoulder of his seat to the seats in the next row, where **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** are sitting. The **Carcosan corporal** follows, and starts closing the door behind him.

Peter Cat

So, *where* are we going?

Carcosan corporal

A village called *Mushad*, on the other side of *Lake Hali*.

There's a *famous observatory* there.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **white panel van** has been waved through a checkpoint outside the city limits, and proceeds along a dirt road that follows the shoreline of Lake Hali. The modern city is in the background; the foreground is dominated by bushes and short trees. The transition from city to country is abrupt.

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

In the background, the **white panel van** approaches a village, kicking up dust from the dirt road it is driving on. It is approaching a village in the foreground. In many ways, this village seems untouched by time; dusk is falling, but there are only a handful of lights.

Carcosan corporal

The *driver* says we will be arriving shortly.

Page 13

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg and **Penny Skragg** are standing on each side of the open doors on the back of the van. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** are stepping out of the back through the open doors. **Penny Skragg** looks up at something in the foreground.

Penny Skragg

Huh.

What *kind* of *observatory* doesn't have a *shutter*?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg and **Camillo Skragg** look up at a dome on top of a high, narrow tower made of limestone. The **Carcosan corporal** stands across from them.

Camillo Skragg

I'm guessing they're not using a *telescope*.

Carcosan corporal

The *Librarian* has been *informed* of your *arrival*.

Your *quarters* are in the *tower*.

Penny Skragg (to Carcosan corporal)

Thank you!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Librarian** looks out through an arched wooden door atop a small landing with a short set of stairs down to the street, and beckons the others to enter.

Librarian

Please, come inside.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Librarian** leads **Camillo Skragg**, **Penny Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Peter Cat** up a spiral stone staircase inside the tower.

Librarian

The *khamalat* will arrive tomorrow morning.

Camillo Skragg

The *who*?

Librarian

One of the *bearers of the veil*.

The *Malique-en-armahrl* will speak through him.

Penny Skragg

That's the "King in Yellow," right?

Librarian

Yes.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The modest quarters in the Library tower, a mostly circular stone room lit by oil lamps on the walls. Four modest beds are in two pairs on each side of the door. **Peter Cat** looks carefully at the oil lamp – to his eyes, it is exotic and alien. **Jinx Bubastis** sits on one of the beds. **Camillo Skragg** looks at his smartphone. **Penny Skragg** sits on another bed, yawns, and stretches.

Camillo Skragg

It looks like a *Renaissance Fair* outside, but the *network coverage* is *great*.

Penny Skragg

I'm *beat*, I need a nap.

Page 14

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg lies on her bed, eyes closed, sleeping lightly. The oil lamps have been dimmed to a soft yellow glow.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg sits up in her dream; she is sitting on the summit of a low mountain.

Box (narration, Penny Skragg)

My uncle *warned* me about the dreams...

I'm on top of a *mountain*, looking down onto a landscape...

Panel 3 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

A Penny Skragg stands on the summit of a low mountain and looks towards the horizon. The horizon looks... strange. The terrain near the edge looks cloudy and indistinct, tiny objects too small to be resolved. There should be a distinct visual impression of vast depth – mountains many hundreds of miles away can be made out as tiny objects. Something brilliant white but thin as the edge of a razor blade defines the horizon, several thousand miles away. The sky is very slightly tilted, with the low side nearest the horizon.

Box (narration, Penny Skragg)

Everything looks *wrong*.

I can see *impossibly far*.

The sky doesn't look *parallel* to the *ground*, like it's *painted on the inside of a giant dome*.

Like I'm *trapped* inside a giant skull.

Looking at the *horizon* is like staring into an *abyss*.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A view over Penny Skragg's shoulder as she looks off into the distance. Something that resembles a column of smoky tendrils stretches from the ground to the dome, marking the inside of the dome with a soot-like layer of dark material.

Box (narration, Penny Skragg)

...and what the *fuck* is *that*?

It's like a *column of smoke* reaching to the *top* of the *dome*.

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close up on Penny Skragg's face as her expression shift to one of terror.

Box (narration, Penny Skragg)

The more I *look at it*, the more I think it's *looking back at me*.

Nope.

Panel 6 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks down at her legs. She's now wearing an ornate pair of over-the-knee boots.

Box (narration, Penny Skragg)

Lucky for me, I've always been a *lucid dreamer*.

Time for my *seven-league boots*.

Page 15

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A distorted perspective as **Penny Skragg** uses her seven-league boots to flee to the horizon, away from the column of smoke. She resembles one of the figures from R. Crumb's "Keep On Truckin'" cartoon. The landscape is warped as her next step takes her hundreds of miles forwards.

Box (*narration, Penny Skragg*)

Every stride's *hundreds of miles*.

Just the thing when it's time to *nope outta here*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The razor-thin white stripe that marked the end of the horizon becomes a high ice wall.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Proportions and perspective return, more or less, to normal. **Penny Skragg** is on top of the ice wall, and walks up to the edge, where the sky is perpendicular to the icy ground.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg hits the sky-wall, which begins to crack.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg crawls through a hole in the dome, into a luminous black void. The composition should be similar to the Flammarion engraving, but with an inky void suffused with light and not crystal spheres and cosmic mechanisms.

Penny Skragg

I push through the dome into the darkness.

I feel like I just *broke out of prison*.

Page 16

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg sits up abruptly in bed, looking like she is gasping for air. **Camillo Skragg** observes her with a mixture of concern and a little bemusement.

Penny Skragg
AAH!

Camillo Skragg
One of *those* dreams?
Are you OK?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg recovers her composure, and swings her feet onto the floor to get out of bed. **Camillo Skragg** looks a relieved.

Penny Skragg
Oh, yeah. It was a *weird* one.

Camillo Skragg
How so?

Penny Skragg
I had to *escape from a flat earth*...

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A dining room in the observatory tower. **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Penny Skragg**, and **Camillo Skragg** have entered from the left of the panel through a wide wooden door. A rectangular table has four places set, two on each side, with a full dinner service. At the head of the table, a young man (**The Volunteer**) lowers a veil over his face. He still looks like a healthy young man. On the back of his left hand, **The Volunteer** bears the **Yellow Sign**. **The Volunteer** sits at a chair identical to the Stranger's chair from Page 10, Panel 2.

Box (narration. top left)
Shortly...

The Volunteer (quietly, from beneath the veil)
He will be with you shortly...
...please have a seat.

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*): A close-up of the table. In the middle of the page, **The King in Yellow** stands in front of the Stranger's chair, gesturing with spread arms beckoning the others to the table, fully transformed into his ancient form. On the left side, **Jinx Bubastis** sits nearest to the head of the table, with a tense expression, alert for an imminent threat. **Peter Cat** takes the next seat on the left, and is looking carefully at **Jinx Bubastis**. **Penny Skragg** takes the chair nearest the head of the table on the right side, still feeling a little disoriented from her dream. **Camillo Skragg** sits at the next place out on the right side of the table and examines the silverware, silently reminding himself to use them from outside to inside – it's been a while since he's seen a full table setting.

The King in Yellow
Thank you for *accepting* my invitation...
...we have *much* to discuss.

Page 17

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow holds one hand over his heart.

The King in Yellow

I imagine you have questions...
...who I *am*, what I *wanted* to tell you...
...let us *begin*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis looks down at her plate, listening carefully, with her hands resting lightly on the table. **Peter Cat** has shifted in his chair to look directly at **The King in Yellow** with an expression of mild surprise.

The King in Yellow (off-panel)

I was *human* once.
A proud son of *Atlantis*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg looks at **The King in Yellow** as he speaks, her expression suggesting fascination. **Camillo Skragg** appears to be ruminating with his elbows on the table.

The King in Yellow (off-panel)

But this was *long ago*.
Being “human” meant *something else* then.
We *walked* among the *stars*.
Reality was our *plaything*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow continues talking, his posture suggesting a mournful aspect.

The King in Yellow

And this place?
Plato called it “*Atlantis*” in his *fables*. We had another name in a language I *dare not speak*.
Now it is a *shattered fragment* of a *great island*.
Settlers from *Al-Andalus* came here and called it “*Kisra*”, which the *Genoese* and *time* turned into “*Carcosa*”.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow stands before his chair, his head bowed. **Jinx Bubastis** looks at **The King in Yellow** with some suspicion, as if she is looking for some kind of inconsistency in his words. **Peter Cat** maintains a studied, neutral expression. **Penny Skragg** is obviously fascinated. **Camillo Skragg** has remembered that he shouldn’t put his elbows on the table, and looks like he has a question he wants to ask.

The King in Yellow

What *shattered* our grand island?
I saw it, and fled into *space*.
Lived as a “flash mind” on the star *Aldebaran* for *millennia* before my *terror* abated.
Before I could *bear* to *return*.

Page 18

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg asks his question. **The King in Yellow** replies, and walks past the behind of **Penny Skragg's** chair as he approaches **Camillo Skragg**.

Camillo Skragg

So, *your people* explored *space*?
You were the ones behind the *colonies*?

The King in Yellow

Yes.
Our *seers* sought out *other worlds*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow slowly approaches **Camillo Skragg**, and traces out a spider-web like pattern as he recalls the process of Atlantean space colonization.

The King in Yellow

We built a web of *shunts* and sent *primitive humans* through them...
...to seed the *places* we found.

Camillo Skragg

But...
...how were you *expecting* that to *work*?

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow looks at **Camillo Skragg** with a certain haughtiness. **Camillo Skragg** is baffled by what he is hearing.

The King in Yellow

You, Mr. Skragg, are a product of an *age of machines*.
You expect *success* to be *measurable* and *reproducible*.
That was not our way.

Camillo Skragg

So what *were* you thinking?

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow crosses his arms in front of him and looks off to the side. While his posture is basically defensive, there is a certain self-mockery at play; he recognizes the ridiculousness of what he is saying.

The King in Yellow

Our *will* be *done*.
I can only *imagine* how that must sound to you, Mr. Skragg.
But I swear, it was *just that simple*.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A full view of the table. **The King in Yellow** stands behind **Camillo Skragg's** chair, and gestures to the servant wheeling a cart with food into the room. **Camillo Skragg** is still processing what he just heard, and looks a little puzzled. **Penny Skragg** has noticed **The King in Yellow's** gentle self-deprecation and is mildly amused. **Jinx Bubastis** looks a little angry, but is holding her tongue. **Peter Cat** looks at **Jinx Bubastis** and **Penny Skragg** and mentally tries to reconcile their expressions.

The King in Yellow

I have *touched* the minds of *modern men*.
Without *preparation*, they *break*.
I show them *power*, and they see *madness*.
Servants! Bring in the food!
Eat, then I will show you *more*.

Page 19

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow leads **Penny Skragg**, **Camillo Skragg**, **Jinx Bubastis**, and **Peter Cat** up a stone spiral staircase to the observatory.

Box (*narration, upper left*)

After a brief meal...

The King in Yellow

Intelligent *moderns* have come to think an *industrial society* oriented towards serving *human needs* is the height of *hubris*...

...they have no *idea*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Observatory is more like a planetarium, a dome of finely-cut marble with an elaborate lantern in the middle. Suspended above the lantern is a half-dome of thin material that appears, for now, to be featureless. **The King in Yellow** ignites the lantern with a fingertip and prepares to lower a mantle over the flame beneath the half-dome. This device is a kind of magic lantern, that will project images on the inside of the dome. The focus in this panel is **The King in Yellow** getting the magic lantern ready, the next panel will be a proper establishing shot of the interior.

The King in Yellow

Pity I was *off-world* when *Plato* wrote his *fables*.

He understood our *nature* but not our *substance*.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The inside of the Observatory is bathed in brilliant white light as the mantle heats up enough to glow; this is an establishing panel, where the form of the room is clearly visible. **The King in Yellow** prepares to lower the dome over the lantern. **Camillo Skragg** shades his eyes with one hand, **Penny Skragg** squints, **Jinx Bubastis** scowls, and **Peter Cat** seems not to notice.

The King in Yellow

There we are.

Now, for what I wanted to *show* you...

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Now that the dome has been lowered over the lantern, an image of the world from Penny's dream (Pages 14 and 15) is projected onto the inside of the dome. **Penny Skragg** gasps visibly.

Penny Skragg (*under her breath*)

I've *been* here...

The King in Yellow

...*this* is the prison we built when our *creations* got out of hand.

And, in *one* case, we locked away a *goddess* from the *outer darkness*.

Page 20

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow points to what appears to be a column of tendrils of smoke, leaving a sooty mark on the dome above.

The King in Yellow

This is Tiamat.

She was *young* when this world was still *cooling*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow turns a little away from the column of smoke, and keeps **Jinx Bubastis** in his peripheral vision. **Jinx Bubastis** stiffens a little as she becomes aware that she's being side-eyed.

The King in Yellow

She and her kind created *immortal souls* as a form of *currency*.

When a mortal *dies*, the *soul* passes through the *Lake of Fire*, and the contradictions of *self* burn away.

For the *Space Bankers*, the *soul* becomes *fungible*, and can then be *minted*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg struggles to understand what he is hearing, and in that struggle, he remembers something, and asks a question. **The King in Yellow** turns a little towards him.

Camillo Skragg

So, when *Charles Fort* said "I think we're property" he wasn't *wrong*.

We're *currency*?

The King in Yellow

Not exactly.

Humans were an *accident*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow turns his attention back to the column of smoke in the distance.

The King in Yellow

Tiamat is the *true* owner of *this world*.

Her *investments* failed, and the *Space Bankers* sent their *Executors*.

Her creations – *dinosaurs* – were *liquidated* to settle her *debts*.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow turns away, back towards the others. He is looking off-panel, trying to read the others' reaction to what he is saying. **Peter Cat** is about to ask a question. **Jinx Bubastis** looks like she wants to be anywhere else. **Camillo Skragg** is visibly struggling to integrate what he is hearing. **Penny Skragg** is slack-jawed, in a mild state of mental shock.

The King in Yellow

We are the *rats* and *cockroaches* that *thrived* in the *ruins*.

For the *Space Bankers*, a *pest control* problem.

Page 21

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat asks a question, and **The King in Yellow** does his best to answer.

Peter Cat

What about *us*?
Our people?

The King in Yellow

Good question!
I'd *speculate* that *your kind* are *too young* to have attracted *their* attention.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow continues talking, gesturing broadly.

The King in Yellow

You haven't *scattered* yourself throughout the *galaxy*.
Or tried to *communicate* with these *elder beings*.
We *got* their *attention*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow shrinks a little, holding his hands in front of him, looking down a little.

The King in Yellow

Tiamat came *here*, and tried to *liquidate* the human race.
We *fought* her, we *imprisoned* her.
And then the *Exterminators* came.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow makes a fist in front of his face.

The King in Yellow

I *fled* when their *gravity weapon* transformed *most* of our island nation into a *lump of collapsed matter*.
It *sank* to the Earth's *core*, some *misguided souls* call it "The Black Sun".

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow turns to **Penny Skragg**.

The King in Yellow

I don't *suppose* your patron, this *Magister*, has told you *any* of this?

Penny Skragg

No.
Is he your *rival*?

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up on **The King in Yellow's** veiled face. What can be seen beneath the veil suggests a somber expression.

The King in Yellow

I *have* no *rivals*.

Page 22

Panel 1 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The King in Yellow turns to face **Camillo Skragg**, **Penny Skragg**, and **Peter Cat**.

The King in Yellow

All I ask is that you do not obey him *blindly*.
Do not *expect* him to *tell the truth*.
The Magister is both *more* and *less* than he seems.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

The King in Yellow now turns towards **Jinx Bubastis**; he reaches beneath his robe for a small box that resembles the kind of boxes used for rings.

The King in Yellow

And now, as for *you*...

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

A close-up of **The King in Yellow**'s hand, which holds the small box. The box is open; inside, a gold coin bearing the **Yellow Sign** stands upright. The coin has a strange, dark aura.

The King in Yellow

...please *listen carefully*.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis stares at the coin and ring box with a cold, hard expression and a raised eyebrow. **The King in Yellow** holds the open box in front of him, and is only partially visible in panel.

The King in Yellow

I *bind* you, *Jnnqae Mrrlo Bebestozh*, and *command* you...
...cast no *alien souls* into the Lake of Fire.
You prey on *humans* now.

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis takes the ring box from **The King in Yellow**'s outstretched hand.

Panel 6 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis snaps the ring box closed, and scowls at **The King in Yellow**.

Jinx Bubastis

I am not *yours* to *bind*, wizard.

Panel 7 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis points an accusing finger at **The King in Yellow**. She is furious. An abstract background might work well here, to emphasize the tension in the room.

Jinx Bubastis

I am *not* one of your *pithed thralls* that you *use* as *meat puppets*.
I *know* bearing *your sign* destroys the soul.
I *know* why you *fear death*—

Page 23

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up of **Jinx Bubastis** as she finishes her accusation, staring down **The King in Yellow**, who is standing off-panel to the left.

Jinx Bubastis

—when you pass through the *Lake of Fire*
and *all contradictions* are *burned away*
NOTHING will remain.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat watches the confrontation with the studied, neutral expression he adopts before doing something extremely violent. It shouldn't be an obvious threat, but it is an example of something that is a recurring theme that readers coming back to this issue might pick up on. Keep it subtle. **Penny Skragg** whispers something to **Camillo Skragg**, who is standing behind her, and he whispers back; what he says seems to disturb her.

Penny Skragg (*whispering to Camillo Skragg*)

“Pithed?”

Camillo Skragg (*whispering to Penny Skragg*)

It's when you *destroy* the *central nervous system* of an *animal*.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The King in Yellow stands, defiant but silent. **Jinx Bubastis** turns towards **Peter Cat**. **Peter Cat** stares down **The King in Yellow**. **Penny Skragg** and **Camillo Skragg** watch tensely.

Peter Cat

We're leaving.

Penny Skragg

We're leaving?

Jinx Bubastis

We're leaving!

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis, **Peter Cat**, **Penny Skragg**, and **Camillo Skragg** head towards the van outside the library tower. It is bright outside, and a beautiful day. **Camillo Skragg** looks out with a wistful expression. Carcosa is beautiful, and he regrets that they will likely never return.

Page 24

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Night, the exterior of **Camillo Skragg**'s house back in Phoenecia, NY.

Box (narrative, upper left)

Back home...

Penny Skragg (from inside the house)

So, what *happened*?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Interior of the kitchen. **Jinx Bubastis** sits at the kitchen table, with the ring box open in front of her. Her eyes are fixed on the coin. **Penny Skragg** stands off to the side, looking at **Jinx Bubastis** with some concern.

Jinx Bubastis

Goetia. Low magic used to summon and coerce *demons*.

He spoke my *true name* and gave an unmistakable *command*.

Penny Skragg

So it was *self-defense*?

Jinx Bubastis

Yes.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat stands behind **Jinx Bubastis** and places his hand on her shoulder. **Jinx Bubastis** covers his hand with hers. **Penny Skragg** stands next to the kitchen table, like in Panel 2. **Camillo Skragg** leans on the kitchen counter.

Jinx Bubastis

Wizards see *everything* as an *instrument* to *serve their will*.

This *trinket* he gave me was meant to *force me to comply*.

Peter Cat

What *is* this coin, really?

Jinx Bubastis

It contains what's left of *Demonlayer's* soul.

Camillo Skragg

Can she... come back?

Jinx Bubastis

No.

It's like an *urn* filled with *ashes* of a *cremated corpse*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

At the kitchen table, **Jinx Bubastis** holds the coin in one hand, between finger and thumb, looking at the face of the coin.

Jinx Bubastis

The *King in Yellow* is a *tragedy*.

So much *knowledge*, offered at a *terrible price*...

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close-up on **Jinx Bubastis**' hand, holding the coin. The **Yellow Sign** is clearly visible on the face of the coin, which has a strange, dark aura.

Jinx Bubastis

...it's a very *human* kind of *madness*.